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WRITING SAMPLES

These two writing samples were prepared specifically for my application to the Communication Officer position in the IPCC WGI Technical Support Unit. They are not official IPCC documents. Together, they show two parts of the role as I understand it: a plain-language explainer of a WGI finding for non-specialist readers, and a mock press release that packages the same finding for the media.

In 2025, while traveling in South America and documenting the horse-rental families along the trail to Vinicunca for my personal project, field/notes, I was struck by the bare rock beneath snow-capped peaks. I could see the human side clearly, but I wanted to better understand the physical science behind the melt. Turning to the IPCC Sixth Assessment Report to answer those questions became the direct catalyst for these writing samples.

I chose tropical glaciers because the Andes hold over 99 percent of them, making the region one of the most visible examples. It gives you a way to talk about complex physical science, like rising freezing levels and the shift from snow to rain, through a landscape people can actually picture.

Sample 1: Explainer[1]

SAMPLE EXPLAINER. WRITING SAMPLE ONLY. NOT AN OFFICIAL IPCC DOCUMENT.

The Ice Above the Trail

The trail up to Vinicunca looks permanent. Striped red and yellow slopes, sharp peaks with snow on top, a line of horses waiting for the next group of walkers. I went in March 2025, and what I mostly noticed was the people working the trail: the guides, and the families renting out their horses and alpacas.

In its Sixth Assessment Report, the Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change (IPCC) details major changes across global ice masses. Working Group I, the part that covers physical science, found that human influence is very likely the main driver of glacier retreat around the world since the 1990s.[2] It also found that mountain glaciers will keep melting for decades or centuries.[3] In the tropical Andes, glaciers have shrunk by roughly 30 to 50 percent since the 1970s, according to a 2013 review, and the retreat is most pronounced for small glaciers at low altitude.[4]

Here is why. A mountain glacier lives on a balance. Snow builds it up at the top, and warmth wears it down at the bottom. In the tropical Andes, the key is the freezing level, the height where the air drops to 0°C. Studies in Peru find that the freezing level has been rising for decades, and that glaciers there are very sensitive to this, because less snow builds up and the surface reflects less sunlight.[5] Put simply, some precipitation that used to fall as snow now falls as rain.

The region matters because more than 99 percent of the world's tropical glaciers are in the Andes, most of them in Peru.[6]

What the melt means for water, farms and the people who rely on both is a different question, and it belongs to Working Group II, which assesses impacts. The IPCC's 2019 special report on the ocean and cryosphere explains the pattern: glacier runoff rises for a while, then falls after a turning point known as "peak water."[7]

On the trail, I saw horses grazing on bare rock under snow-capped peaks. That is what I saw. What sits behind it is in the reports: glaciers have been retreating worldwide since the 1990s, humans are very likely the main cause, and the melting will go on for decades or centuries. How the families on those slopes will cope is a question for Working Group II, and one I would like to understand better.

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[1] The Explainer (The Ice Above the Trail): Written for general readers and web audiences. It opens with what I saw on the trail, explains the physics of the melt using exact IPCC terms and makes a clear point of drawing the line between Working Group I (the physical science of ice loss) and Working Group II (the downstream impacts on water and communities).

[2] IPCC AR6 WGI, Summary for Policymakers, A.1.5.

[3] IPCC AR6 WGI, Summary for Policymakers, B.5.2; Chapter 9, Section 9.5.

[4] Rabatel, A. et al. (2013). Current state of glaciers in the tropical Andes: a multi-century perspective on glacier evolution and climate change. *The Cryosphere*, 7, 81–102.

[5] Schauwecker, S. et al. (2017). The freezing level in the tropical Andes, Peru: an indicator for present and future glacier extents. *Journal of Geophysical Research: Atmospheres*, 122(10), 5172–5189.

[6] Rabatel, A. et al. (2013). Current state of glaciers in the tropical Andes: a multi-century perspective on glacier evolution and climate change. *The Cryosphere*, 7, 81–102.

[7] IPCC (2019). Special Report on the Ocean and Cryosphere in a Changing Climate, Chapter 2, FAQ 2.1.

Sample 2: Mock Press Release[8]

SAMPLE MOCK RELEASE. WRITING SAMPLE ONLY. NOT AN OFFICIAL IPCC DOCUMENT.

For approval and immediate release

What the IPCC says about the vanishing ice of the tropical Andes

QUEZON CITY, PHILIPPINES — 11 November 2026 — Glaciers around the world have been retreating since the 1990s, and human influence is very likely the main driver, according to the IPCC's Sixth Assessment Report (2021). The report also finds that mountain glaciers will keep melting for decades or centuries.

A new plain-language explainer, The Ice Above the Trail, sets out these findings for general readers, starting from the trail to Vinicunca (Rainbow Mountain) in Peru. The tropical Andes hold more than 99 percent of the world's tropical glaciers, and studies there show a freezing level that has been rising for decades. The explainer separates two questions: what the physical science shows, which Working Group I assesses, and what the melt means for water and communities, which Working Group II assesses.

"[Quote reserved for an approved spokesperson on why clear communication of glacier science matters.]"

Notes to editors

- IPCC AR6 Working Group I, Summary for Policymakers, sections A.1.5 and B.5.2.
- Andes' share of tropical glaciers: Rabatel et al. (2013), *The Cryosphere*, 7, 81–102. Freezing level: Schauwecker et al. (2017), *Journal of Geophysical Research: Atmospheres*, 122(10). Peak water: IPCC Special Report on the Ocean and Cryosphere (2019), Chapter 2, FAQ 2.1.

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[8] **The Mock Press Release:** Formatted for journalists and news desks. It boils the explainer down into a simple,wire-ready release to show how WGI findings can be packaged quickly for media outreach.